

From pages 248-254 of the book "History of the Novi Sad Jews" (Istorija Novosadskih Jevreja).

This part written by Dr. Franja Amir Ofner (1913-2011), in a section titled: "Participation of the Jews of Novi Sad in international events 1939-1941". Written in Serbian.

(Re Ofner, see <https://www.jewishvirtuallibrary.org/ofner-francis-amir> and <https://collections.ushmm.org/search/catalog/irn502815>)

"ILLEGAL" SHIPS OF REFUGEES IN NOVI SAD

One of these activities was the tasks assigned to the revisionist movement in Yugoslavia in connection with the "illegal" emigration to Eretz Yisrael. Since a large part of the refugees used the Danube boats to sail to the Black Sea, the Yugoslav sector of that international "underground shipping" was of vital importance, namely, without passing through the Yugoslav part of Danube, i.e. without permission from the Yugoslav authorities for the docking of ships and without supplying ships and refugees in the Yugoslav part of the Danube and without money to cover the costs of these activities, the entire Danube rescue route would be impossible.

The culmination of Novi Sad's activity in this field came in 1939. Then, the two largest ships from Bratislava - namely "0-1" and "0-2" - passed by. They had on board nearly a thousand Jewish refugees of various ages from Czechoslovakia, Austria, Poland and Germany. After they had been provided with food and clothing in Novi Sad, they were returned to Kamenica. After two weeks in that small town, they continued on to a Romanian port on the Black Sea. There they were transferred to an overseas ship organized by Betarim from Romania, France and Eretz Yisrael; the most active among them were Eliyahu Galezeri and Yaakov Schieber, both now in Tel Aviv, the late Ari Jabotinsky [son of], later a professor at the Technion in Haifa, and the late Shimshon Yunichman, later a member of the Knesset in Jerusalem. The refugees then continued from the Romanian Black Sea port across the Bosphorus and the Mediterranean. They managed to break through the English blockade and safely arrived in Eretz Yisrael.

Of the other groups we helped at that time, I remember the ship led by Citrom, a Beitar leader from Czechoslovakia, and several smaller groups that passed through Yugoslavia and Bulgaria. There they were picked up and shipped to Eretz Israel by Marcel Bakit and Reuven Franco, both Beitar leaders who had managed to get to Eretz Israel before the Nazi occupation of Bulgaria. In addition to the groups, there were of course a number of individual families and even ad hoc groupings of just two or three young people from the occupied or endangered countries. Many of these needed and received help to pass through Yugoslavia and survive, on their way to Thessaloniki, Athens, and Istanbul, and from there to their old and new homeland.

ACTIVISTS IN NOVI SAD AND ELSEWHERE

A considerable number of Novi Sad and non-Novu Sad Jews assisted in these efforts. Dr. Dohány, Viktor Stark, former Yugoslav Consul in Haifa, the late Laszlo-Levinger Leib, director of "Kulpin", the late Dr. Gruner, a Belgrade lawyer originally from Subotica, the late Djuro Lang and I were involved in negotiations with the authorities and the acquisition of various permits.

In the case of the "0-1" and "0-2", to our surprise, Stark and Dr. Gruner managed to obtain a permit for free from an otherwise corrupt head of the State Protection Department in the Belgrade Ministry of Internal Affairs. "These are Slavic Jews; these are our people," the official declared, refusing to accept a bribe.

Shipping problems were left to "Gutschi" for 8 months. "Gutschi" was Laci Guttmann, then my successor as Natziv of Beitar, now the city librarian

in Haifa. Mirko Popper, Rudi Guttmann and others
in the shipping company "Guttmann and Frank" worked with
"Gutschi" in that field.

The reception of refugees and the mobilization of contributions
was supported by numerous other Vojvodina residents and non-Vojvodina
residents, [Vojvodina is the district containing Novi Sad] often
regardless of party affiliation. At the risk of forgetting
many, in the speed with which I need to finish this article,
I ask for your forgiveness if I have omitted any active contributors.
I remember Dr. Petar Svarc, now a professor,
at the University of Novi Sad, with his wife, Dr.
Aurel Friedmann now from Naharia, deceased. Dr.
Poldi Mojzeš, Vlado Kraus, Dr. Leo Fischer,
Dr. Aladar Vermée, Feika Wild, Dr. Kaljuski,
Albert Dragoner and Mandil from Belgrade, Slavko
Dragoner, Teodor Bichler, Dr. Boran, Jaéa
Mr. and Master Hafner from Zagreb, Dr. Deutsch
and Braca Frankel from Mol, Dr. Zentai Laci from
Sente, pharmacist "Rugafo" Reuven Friedmann
from Küle, Dr. Smukler and Dr. Stein from Osijek,
Julije Breuer from Sombor, deceased. "Grandfather" Dr.
Otto Mandl with his wife Sidika. There was no end
to the loyal help from the youth, such as the late
Dr. Laci Lipkovic, Dezsko Händler, Dr. Edgar-Schlomo Tadmor,
now on the board of the Weizmann Institute, Itzhak Werber, now
one of the leaders of the Israeli Atomic Institute in Dimona,
Laszlo-Levinger Karéi, Brothers Birnbaum, Ing. Djura-Reuven Roder,
now from Haifa, and the Hamburgers from Sombor, Erna Rozenberg from
Zagreb, Bora. Glass and Grün. Boriéka from Subotica, Sekel Mirko
from Kula, Bandi Ziegler and Gabor Pali from Backe Topole, little Yitzhak Gross,
Sami Wallach from Sarajevo, Albert Mizrahi from Skopje, etc.

The care of our part of the refugees in Šabac was the concern
and responsibility of Ilika Ofner, my wife, who was of course
also active in other fields of our activity. Together with Mirko Popper
and Rudi Guttmann, Ilika tirelessly and regularly collected and brought
clothing, food and money to Šabac. About 1,200 refugees had been interned
there since the summer of 1940, after which they spent a terrible winter on
frozen ships in Kladovo. But that group was organized by "Hehalutz" in Vienna.
Their maintenance in Šabac was made possible - very modestly - by
the philanthropic body of American Jewry, the Joint Distribution Committee,
through the then-Chairman of the Council in Belgrade, Simo Spicer.
Almost 1,000 people from that group were killed by
the Germans, while only two hundred reached Eretz Yisrael a few days
before the occupation.

All our activities related to refugees were carried out on a voluntary
basis and none of us were paid. We even paid our expenses exclusively
from our own private funds, and if it was difficult for any of us,
we helped them out of our own pockets. That was a case with all the
other activities described here.

NOVOSAD'S HELP TO THE ALLIES.

In addition to working to rescue Jewish refugees, several members of
our group became active in organizing an economic boycott against
Nazi groups in Yugoslavia. Dr. Deutsch of Mol paid for this activity
with his life in the first days of the fascist occupation in the
dark spring of 1941.

A group of Novi Sad Jews had already joined the Allied war effort
a year and a half before Yugoslavia turned against Nazi Germany.
Dr. Dohany, - if I remember correctly, together with Reuven Hecht
of Basel (now owner of the "Dagon" forces in Haifa) - established
a connection with the British Embassy in Belgrade and offered to
help them in the war against Hitlerism. Dr. Dohany's activities
led to significant results in two directions. Through one of his
anti-Nazi contacts in the German Embassy in Belgrade - a nephew of
Dr. Hjalmar Schachts - he managed to place at the disposal of the
Allies a number of Nazi military, political, and economic secrets.
In addition, he managed to enable British economic agents in Yugoslavia

to seize some of the most important resources in the country and thereby make it difficult for the Germans to supply a number of economic fields.

"GESTAPO" PREPARING FOR AXIS VETO

The Nazis arrested Dr. Dohany and forcibly took him to Belgrade shortly after the occupation. For over four years, Dr. Dohany was held in prisons and concentration camps in Yugoslavia and Germany. He was released several times and was arrested again each time at the last minute. In 1942, an official at the

British Embassy in Istanbul arranged for Dohany's name to be placed on a "list of Allied spies" that the British sent to the Germans through a neutral government for "agent exchange." This seems to have contributed to Dr. Dohany's remaining in captivity.

The same Gestapo unit from Belgrade, which had arrested Dr. Dohany, was supposed to arrest me. They searched for me in my apartment on Tsar Lazar Street, but fortunately for me, as a Hungarian they had already taken me to forced labor, so the Gestapo did not find me at home. But the Gestapo was persistent and almost managed to get hold of me in the spring of 1942, when I was hiding in Budapest. The Germans apparently found out that I was there, so they officially requested my extradition from the Hungarian authorities. With the help of a police reporter for a Hungarian newspaper, Dr. Koloss, and one of his pro-Allied friends in the Police Department, I managed to arrange for the extradition documents to be withheld until my escape from Budapest to Istanbul in June of that year.

The Gestapo's persistence in that case can only be explained by the fact that I, together with Mlrko Bot, now in Chile, in collaboration with Major Vladimir Perisent, was modestly involved in the preparations for the anti-Nazi coup of General Simović of March 27, 1941. For the Nazis, this coup was the most unpleasant humiliation they had suffered since they came to power, and therefore they seemed to be trying to take as much revenge as they could. And since the main leaders of the coup managed to disappear in time into the country or abroad, they went after the small collaborators.

One of the most notorious members of our group, "Gutsche" Laci Guttmann, was twice charged for his involvement in the group's activities. First, he was arrested by the Yugoslav authorities during the royal era and held for six weeks in the Belgrade political prison. Later, he was held for six months in the notorious Budapest prison on Margit Körüt street, the same prison where Hana Szenes was murdered.

It is difficult to talk about that terrible period of Nazism and the Holocaust without remembering with sadness and pain all those who paid with their lives for the atrocities of Hitlerism, Hungarian fascism and for the indifference of great and small powers. The world has lost in them just and righteous freedom fighters. And for the Jewish people constructive citizens of the future state of Israel.

And us? We have become poorer in the dearest thing that man can acquire: in friends.